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TEACHER GUIDE

Using the Differentiated Student Handouts

A guide to self-selection and flexible differentiation · The Harlem Renaissance

WHAT'S INCLUDED

Each Mini Museum lesson plan includes three color-coded student handouts at different challenge levels. Students choose which level they want to work on based on how they feel about the topic — not based on a permanent ability label.

GREEN LEVEL
MORE SUPPORT

"I want more support"

Simplified vocabulary, more scaffolding, visual aids

YELLOW LEVEL
GRADE LEVEL

"I'm ready for a challenge"

Grade-level appropriate, independent work

RED LEVEL
GO DEEPER

"I want to go deeper"

Extension activities, open-ended challenges

HOW TO USE THESE HANDOUTS

Five steps

1
Print the levels you need

You can print all three or just the ones you anticipate using.

2
Display with color-coded labels

Set out stacks with clear signs or place in color-coded folders.

3
Let students choose

Emphasize: *"This is about challenge preference TODAY, not about how smart you are."*

4
Normalize switching

If a student wants a different challenge, let them switch. This builds metacognition.

5
No justification required

Students don't have to explain why they chose their level.

WHAT EACH HANDOUT INCLUDES

All three levels cover the same core concepts but adjust complexity of vocabulary, amount of scaffolding, depth of analysis required, and independence expected.

All three levels include: connection to exhibition artifacts, a take-home element for parent engagement, and reflection questions — and can be completed in class OR at home.

LANGUAGE MATTERS

SAY THIS

"Choose the challenge level that feels right for you today."

"Green gives more support. Yellow is grade-level. Red goes deeper. All three are good choices."

"You can switch levels anytime."

AVOID

"Green is for struggling students."

"Red is for advanced students."

"Why did you pick that level?"

WHY SELF-SELECTION WORKS

Choice without labels

- ✓ **Removes stigma:** No public ability grouping. Students aren't labeled "low" or "high."
- ✓ **Allows flexibility:** A student might choose Green for science (unfamiliar) and Red for ELA (confident).
- ✓ **Respects daily variation:** Students might choose differently on Monday (tired) vs. Thursday (energized).
- ✓ **Builds agency:** Students develop self-awareness about when they need support vs. challenge.
- ✓ **Differentiates without labeling:** You're meeting diverse needs without fixed groups.

ADAPTING FOR YOUR CLASSROOM

If you prefer teacher assignment	You can still use these handouts by assigning specific levels to specific students based on your knowledge of their needs. The materials work both ways.
If you want to modify	Treat each handout as a starting point: leave out a part, add a question, or shorten the writing to suit your class.
If you only want one level	That's fine too! Use whichever level best matches your class.

WHAT THE RESEARCH SAYS

Student self-selection of challenge level (sometimes called *"differentiation by choice"*) has been shown to increase student motivation and engagement, develop metacognitive skills, reduce anxiety around differentiation, build growth mindset, and allow teachers to differentiate without public tracking.

THE GOAL

Every student engages with the core content at a level that challenges them appropriately. Some need more support to access the content. Some need extensions to stay engaged. Most are ready for grade-level work. All deserve choice and respect.

QUESTIONS?

These handouts are designed to make differentiation easier for you, not harder. If something isn't working, adjust it. The structure is a tool, not a rule.

Most importantly: the handouts are optional. The lesson plan itself provides everything you need. The handouts are an additional resource for extending learning, providing practice, or sending work home.

Every Harlem Renaissance lesson plan has its Green, Yellow and Red handouts beside it at minimuseumproject.org/exhibitions/harlem-renaissance/resources.